

Dylan Spencer, Ph.D.

Assistant Professor, Georgia Southern University

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🎓 [Google Scholar](#) | Citations: 58 | *h*-index: 5 | *i*10-index: 11

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Criminology & Criminal Justice, University of South Carolina	2022
M.A. Criminal Justice, Radford University	2018
B.S. Forest Resources & Environmental Conservation, Virginia Tech	2014
<i>Minor: Forestry</i>	

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Assistant Professor, Georgia Southern University Department of Criminal Justice and Criminology	2024 – Present
Assistant Professor, South Dakota State University School of Psychology, Sociology and Rural Studies	2022 – 2024

RESEARCH AFFILIATIONS

Institute for Water and Health, Georgia Southern University	2024 – Present
South Dakota Governor's Center on the Illicit Economy, South Dakota State University	2023 – 2024
Department of Natural Resource Management, South Dakota State University	2023 – 2024

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Crime & Place | Quantitative & Spatial Methods | Conservation Criminology | Crime Science | Policing

PUBLICATIONS

(15 peer-reviewed journal articles / 3 book chapters / 1 technical report / 1 public scholarship article)

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles (*Denotes student co-author)

- Pires, S. F., Guerette, R. T., Del Rio, J., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2026). Further evidence for situational determinants of crime: The role of environmental and geographic features in explaining violence hotspots in Colombia, South America. *Crime Science*. [DOI](#)
- Lockwood, A., **Spencer, M. D.**, Boehme, H. M., Davallou, J.*, & Elligson, R. (2025). Discretion in immigration enforcement: How non-federal officers navigate policy mandates and moral judgements. *Journal of Experimental Criminology*. [DOI](#)
- Spencer, M. D.**, & Mitre-Becerril, D. (2025). Do urban greenways reduce crime? A quasi-experimental study of the Atlanta beltline. *Journal of Quantitative Criminology*. [DOI](#)
- Cohen, N. D.*, & **Spencer, M. D.** (2025). Recreation and disarray: Analysis of disorder in U.S. national parks. *Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism*, 51, 100936. [DOI](#)
- Spencer, M. D.**, Christiansen, E.*, Pires, S. F., Tsai, C.*, Gondhali, U.*, & Petrossian, G. A. (2025). Identifying and explaining the distribution of Chinese-affiliated ports around the world: A case control design. *Ocean and Coastal Management*, 269, 107819. [DOI](#)
- Spencer, M. D.**, Schnell, C., & DeWitt, S. (2025). The line from platform to peril: A longitudinal analysis of crime patterns at light rail stations in Charlotte, NC. *Journal of Experimental Criminology*. [DOI](#)
- Spencer, M. D.**, Wilson, A., & Bolin, R. (2025). Policing and corrections in the classroom: Criminal justice students' perceptions of course material and career attractiveness. *Journal of Criminal Justice Education*. [DOI](#)
- Boehme, H. M., Klein, B. R., **Spencer, M. D.**, Jones, A.*, McMains-Nurisio, M.*, Morgan, K.*, & Trowbridge, J.* (2025). Social determinants of health, driving time to trauma hospitals, racial composition, and firearm violence in South Carolina. *Injury Prevention*. [DOI](#)

9. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (2025). Risky facilities, physical site-features, and comparing crime between urban parks. *Security Journal*, 38, 1. [DOI](#)
10. Singh, A. M.*, Pires, S. F., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2024). Using a spatial access measure to assess the relationship between alcohol outlet types and various violent crimes in the Bronx, NY. *Applied Spatial Analysis and Policy*, 17, 1413–1433. [DOI](#)
11. Petrossian, G. A., Pires, S. F., **Spencer, M. D.**, & Cohen, N. D.* (2024). An empirical assessment of seaports as facilitators of FOC-flagged transshipment landings. *Crime Science*, 13, 10. [DOI](#)
12. Schnell, C., DeWitt, S., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2024). The role of neighborhoods in the age of crime hot spots: A multi-level theory of the spatial distribution of robbery in Chicago. *Crime & Delinquency*, 70, 2855–2881. [DOI](#)
13. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (2022). Reinvestigating the relationship between cities and the spatial distribution of robbery: A tale of eight cities. *Journal of Criminal Justice*, 82, 102003. [DOI](#)
14. Schnell, C., **Spencer, M. D.**, Mancik, A., Porter, L., Ready, J., & Alpert, G. (2022). Expanding research on investigations of officer-involved shootings: An experimental evaluation of question timing on police officer's memory recall. *Criminal Justice and Behavior*, 49, 1031–1049. [DOI](#)
15. **Spencer, M. D.**, Green, E. K., & Bolin, R. M. (2021). Exploring the relationship between fishing regulations and angler compliance in Virginia. *American Journal of Criminal Justice*, 46, 815–836. [DOI](#)

Book Chapters

1. **Spencer, M. D.**, Aris, K.*, & Petrossian, G. A. (In press). Mapping blue harm: Spatial vulnerability of deep-sea mining exploration zones. In A. Nurse, T. Wyatt, M. Pons, E. Doornbos, & G. Petrossian (Eds.), *Blue criminology: Examining crime and harm against marine environments*. Bristol University Press.
2. **Spencer, M. D.**, Posick, C., & Colon-Gaud, C. (In press). Improving water quality for safer communities: How criminology and river ecology can collaborate on conservation and justice. In W. Moreto (Ed.), *Environmental Crime and Harm Prevention*. Routledge.
3. Schnell, C., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2025). Micro-places, multi-level frameworks, and modeling the spatial granularity of crime. In R. Wickes & D. Oberwittler (Eds.), *The handbook on cities and crime* (pp. 125–140). Edward Elgar Publishing. [DOI](#)

Technical Reports

1. **Spencer, M. D.** (2020). *The problem of wildlife poaching on U.S. federal lands*. A Problem-Solving Guide: Wilderness Problems, Guide No. 1. Center for Problem-Oriented Policing, Arizona State University. [Link](#)

Public Scholarship

1. **Spencer, M. D.**, Petrossian, G. A., & Pires, S. F. (2026, March 4). Far from random, China's global port network is clustering near the world's riskiest trade routes. *The Conversation*. [DOI](#).
Also published in French. [DOI](#)

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

Manuscripts Under Review

1. Pires, S. F., **Spencer, M. D.**, Petrossian, G. A., Christiansen, E.*, & Gondhali, U.* (revise and resubmit). Predicting dark vessel fishing off West Africa: A micro-spatial approach. *Marine Policy*.
2. **Spencer, M. D.**, Cohen, N. D.*, & Connealy, N. (revise and resubmit). When wildfires suppress crime: A spatial analysis of post-wildfire trends in Los Angeles. *Applied Geography*.
Preprint available at SSRN. [DOI](#)
3. Mitre-Becerril, D., & **Spencer, M. D.** (under review). Illuminating crime prevention: Evidence from Washington, DC's street lighting upgrade. *Criminology & Public Policy*.
Preprint available at SSRN. [DOI](#)
4. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (under review). Risky facilities and the legacy of Ronald Clarke: Developing a new typology of risky facilities to improve situational crime prevention strategies. *Criminology & Public Policy*.
Preprint available at SSRN. [DOI](#)
5. Markel, P., **Spencer, M. D.**, & Arends, R. (under review). New roads don't pave themselves: Building an integrated community for climate-behavioral research. *Journal of Criminal Justice*.

6. **Spencer, M. D.** (under review). Best practices in crime mapping: Policy-driven approaches to visualizing spatial crime variability. *Crime Science*.
7. Connealy, N., Dulisse, B., & **Spencer, M. D.** (under review). Eyes on the sky: A descriptive evaluation of police drone deployments in Portland, Oregon. *Police Practice and Research*.
8. Petrossian, G. A., **Spencer, M. D.**, & Nunphong, T. (under review). Developing typologies of emerging harms of wildlife crime. *Annual Review of Animal Biosciences*.

Working Papers

1. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Cohen, N. D.* (in preparation). A problem-oriented approach to crowding at overlooks on U.S. federal lands.
Topic accepted pending full review at Center for Problem-Oriented Policing.
2. **Spencer, M. D.**, Petrossian, G. A., & von Ferber, J.* (in preparation). Hybrid opportunity structures: The geography of online wildlife trade.
Planned submission to Journal of Criminal Justice.
3. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Cohen, N. D.* (in preparation). What drives wildlife poaching? A machine-learning aided systematic review of offender motivations in North America.
Planned submission to Conservation Biology.
4. Pires, S. F., **Spencer, M. D.**, & Christiansen, E.* (in preparation). Spatial patterns and co-locations of FOC dark vessels in West Africa.
Abstract accepted for special issue in Applied Geography.
5. **Spencer, M. D.**, Petrossian, G. A., & Cohen, N. D.* (in preparation). Why conservation laws fail: A systematic review of enforcement challenges.
Planned submission to Conservation Science and Practice.

FUNDED RESEARCH

(Total Awarded: \$20,000)

Funded

1. **Co-Investigator**, Socio-Environmental Systems of Rural Health. South Dakota State University, Division of Research and Economic Development. *PI: P. Markel; Co-PIs: M. D. Spencer & R. Arends* (\$15,000; July 2023 – November 2024).
2. **Principal Investigator**, Public Transportation and Crime. University of South Carolina, Office of the Vice President for Research. *PI: M. D. Spencer; Co-PI: C. Schnell* (\$5,000; May 2020 – July 2021).

Under Review

1. **Co-Principal Investigator**, Affordable Materials Grants, Round 29: Transformation Grants. University System of Georgia Board of Regents. *PI: D. Derlic; Co-PIs: M. D. Spencer, G. Baas, & M. DeLeon* (\$20,000; May 2026 – May 2027).

DISSERTATION

The Spatial Variability of Crime: A Review of Methodological Choice, Proposed Models, and Methods for Illustrating the Phenomenon. [Link](#)

Co-Chairs: Dr. Cory Schnell & Dr. Robert Kaminski

Committee: Dr. Ashley Mancik & Dr. Andrew Lemieux

MEDIA COVERAGE

1. Jackson, K. (2026, March 19). Why we feel so safe in nature and how that can put us at risk. *Outside Magazine*. [Link](#). Includes interview with author.
2. Mekles, J. (2026, March 7). National park death exposes repeated rule violations as tourists take dangerous risks. *Fox News*. [Link](#). Includes interview with author.

3. Roberts, J. (2025, November 17). National parks are overwhelmingly safe spaces, says study. *National Parks Traveler*. [Link](#). *References Cohen & Spencer (2025)*.
4. Lehman, C.F. (2025, October 16). The other reason Americans don't use mass transit. *The Atlantic*. [Link](#). *References Spencer, Schnell, & DeWitt (2025)*.
5. Lehman, C.F., & Mangual, R. (2025, September 16). How to prevent random violence. *The Atlantic*. [Link](#). *References Spencer, Schnell, & DeWitt (2025)*.

PRESENTATIONS

(22 Conferences / 13 Invited Talks / 4 Guest Lectures)

Conferences (*Denotes student co-presenter)

1. **Spencer, M. D.**, Christiansen, E.*, Pires, S. F., Tsai, C. H.*, Gondhali, U.*, & Petrossian, G. A. (2025). Identifying and explaining the distribution of Chinese-affiliated ports around the world. Invited panel presentation at the American Society of Criminology, Washington, DC.
2. Pires, S. F., **Spencer, M. D.**, Petrossian, G. A., Christiansen, E.*, & Gondhali, U.* (2025). Predicting dark vessel fishing off West Africa: A micro-spatial approach. Southern Criminal Justice Association, Charleston, SC.
3. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (2025). Urban parks, risky facilities, and crime: An open data analysis of built environments. European Society of Criminology, Athens, GR.
4. Davallou, J.*, Lockwood, A., **Spencer, M. D.**, Elligson, R., & Boehme, H. M. (2025). Measuring local law enforcement perceptions of ICE intervention. Georgia Southern Student Scholars Symposium (GS4), Savannah, GA.
5. Cohen, N. D.*, & **Spencer, M. D.** (2025). Recreation and disarray: Analysis of disorder in U.S. national parks. Academy of Criminal Justice Sciences, Denver, CO.
6. **Spencer, M. D.**, DeWitt, S., & Schnell, C. (2024). Analyzing crime patterns surrounding light rail expansion in Charlotte, NC. American Society of Criminology, San Francisco, CA.
7. Pires, S. F., **Spencer, M. D.**, Petrossian, G. A., Christiansen, E.*, & Gondhali, U.* (2024). A comparative modeling study of potential IUU fishing off the coast of West Africa. Invited panel presentation at the American Society of Criminology, San Francisco, CA.
8. Cohen, N. D.*, & **Spencer, M. D.** (2024). Evaluating security features in a U.S. national park: A crime science perspective. The International Symposium on Environmental Criminology and Crime Analysis, Yerevan, Armenia.
9. **Spencer, M. D.**, Wilson, A., & Bolin, R. (2024). Understanding the intersection of context and criminology in teaching and learning. Academy of Criminal Justice Sciences, Chicago, IL.
10. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (2023). Running for fun, not my life! A spatial analysis of crime at public recreation sites. American Society of Criminology, Philadelphia, PA.
11. Petrossian, G. A., Pires, S. F., **Spencer, M. D.**, & Cohen, N. D.* (2023). An empirical assessment of seaports as facilitators of FOC-flagged transshipment landings. American Society of Criminology, Philadelphia, PA.
12. **Spencer, M. D.** (2022). Best practices for illustrating the spatial variability of crime: Re-imagining the crime map. American Society of Criminology, Atlanta, GA.
13. DeWitt, S., Schnell, C., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2022). A tale of two (way) fixed effects: Applying modern statistical corrections to studying the impact of the Charlotte light rail expansions. Southern Criminal Justice Association, Asheville, NC.
14. **Spencer, M. D.**, Mancik, A., & Lemieux, A. (2022). A systematic review of the methodological choice of research on the spatial variability of crime. Academy of Criminal Justice Sciences, Las Vegas, NV.
15. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (2021). An exploration of the spatial variability of crime within and between seven U.S. cities. American Society of Criminology, Chicago, IL.
16. **Spencer, M. D.**, Schnell, C., & DeWitt, S. (2021). The disruptive impact of public transportation expansion on crime: A time series analysis of light rail train stations in Charlotte, NC. Discover UofSC, Columbia, SC.
17. **Spencer, M. D.**, Schnell, C., & DeWitt, S. (2020). The disruptive impact of public transportation expansion on crime: A time series analysis. American Society of Criminology, Washington, DC. **Accepted; Conference Cancelled (COVID-19)*

18. Schnell, C., **Spencer, M. D.**, Mancik, A., Porter, L., Ready, J., & Alpert, G. (2020). Advancing research on memory accuracy after officer-involved shootings: An experimental evaluation of the effect of question timing on recall. Academy of Criminal Justice Sciences, San Antonio, TX. **Accepted; Conference Cancelled (COVID-19)*
19. **Spencer, M. D.**, & Schnell, C. (2019). Exploring the hierarchical spatial distribution of crime: The concentration and stability of robberies at street segments within and between Chicago's neighborhood clusters. American Society of Criminology, San Francisco, CA.
20. **Spencer, M. D.** (2019). Problem-oriented wildlife protection: Poaching prevention on U.S. federal lands. Southeast Association of Fish & Wildlife Agencies, Hilton Head, SC.
21. **Spencer, M. D.** (2019). Problem-oriented wildlife protection: Poaching prevention on U.S. federal lands. Discover USC, Columbia, SC.
22. **Spencer, M. D.** (2018). Exploring the relationship between fishing regulations and angler compliance in Virginia. Northeast Association of Fish & Wildlife Agencies, Burlington, VT.

Invited Talks

1. Davallou, J., Lockwood, A., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2026). Discretion in immigration enforcement: How non-federal officers navigate judgements surrounding children. Posters at the Capitol, Atlanta, GA. *Student presenter; faculty mentor.*
2. Posick, C., & **Spencer, M. D.** (2025). Plant thieves: Botanic crimes & its consequences. The Botanic Garden at Georgia Southern University, Statesboro, GA.
3. **Spencer, M. D.** (2025). Integrating criminology and conservation science: Applications and future research. Warnell School of Forestry and Natural Resources, University of Georgia, Athens, GA.
4. **Spencer, M. D.** (2023). What's next for crime and place research? Netherlands Institute for the Study of Crime and Law Enforcement, Amsterdam, NL.
5. **Spencer, M. D.** (2023). Crime prevention, natural resources, and the illicit economy. South Dakota Governor's Research Center, Virtual.
6. **Spencer, M. D.** (2023). Bridging the gap between criminology and natural resources. Department of Natural Resource Management, South Dakota State University, Brookings, SD.
7. **Spencer, M. D.** (2022). Machine learning: A tool for systematic reviews. School of Psychology, Sociology and Rural Studies, South Dakota State University, Brookings, SD.
8. **Spencer, M. D.** (2021). Graduate school and research. Entering Research Panel, University of South Carolina, Virtual.
9. **Spencer, M. D.** (2020). Grading recommendations and best practices. Teaching Assistant Orientation, University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC.
10. **Spencer, M. D.** (2020). Social science Q&A. Teaching Assistant Orientation, University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC.
11. **Spencer, M. D.** (2020). Using R and RStudio for statistical analysis. PowerSchool LLC, Content Department, Virtual.
12. **Spencer, M. D.** (2020). Migrating to an online teaching environment. PowerSchool LLC, Content Department, Virtual.
13. **Spencer, M. D.** (2018). Geographic information systems. PowerSchool LLC, Content Department, Roanoke, VA.

Guest Lectures

1. **Spencer, M. D.** (2025). Crime mapping using R. Dr. Gohar Petrossian's Graduate Crime Mapping Course, John Jay College, Virtual.
2. **Spencer, M. D.** (2020). Descriptive spatial statistics. Dr. Cory Schnell's Graduate Crime and Place Course, University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC.
3. **Spencer, M. D.** (2019–2021). Routine activities approach. Dr. Ashley Mancik's Communities and Crime Course, University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC.
4. **Spencer, M. D.** (2019–2021). Crime prevention through environmental design. Dr. Ashley Mancik's Communities and Crime Course, University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

(*Denotes online or hybrid course)

Graduate Level

Georgia Southern University

- Crime Mapping (SP 2026*)
- Seminar in Law Enforcement (SU 2026*)
- Criminology Seminar — Crime Prevention (SU 2025*)
- Criminological Theory (F 2025)
- Environmental Crime & Justice (SU 2024*, SP 2025)
- Statistics for Social Science (F 2024)
- Quantitative Research Design (F 2024*)

Undergraduate Level

Georgia Southern University

- Introduction to Policing (SU 2026*)
- Applied Statistics in CJ & Criminology Research (SP 2025*, F 2025*, SP 2026)
- Investigations (SU 2025*)

South Dakota State University

- Advanced Criminology — Capstone (SP 2023*, SP 2024)
- Criminal Investigations (F 2022*, SP 2023, F 2023*, SP 2024)
- Introduction to Criminal Justice (SP 2023*, SU 2023*, F 2023, SP 2024, SU 2024*)
- Policing in a Free Society (F 2022, F 2023*)

Radford University

- Research Methods (SP 2022*)

University of South Carolina

- Policing (F 2020*, SP 2021*)
- Sociology of Crime (F 2019, SP 2020, F 2021, SP 2022*)

SERVICE

Journal Reviewer

American Journal of Preventive Medicine, Computational Urban Science, Crime Prevention and Community Safety, Crime Science, Humanities and Social Sciences Communications, Journal of Criminal Justice, Journal of Geovisualization and Spatial Analysis, Journal of Outdoor Recreation and Tourism, Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency, Population Research and Policy Review, Research in Transportation Business & Management, Security Journal, Victims & Offenders.

Departmental Service

Georgia Southern University

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|---------------------------------|----------------|
| Chair, Faculty Search Committee | 2025 – 2026 |
| Graduate Committee Member | 2024 – Present |
| Undergraduate Committee Member | 2024 – Present |

South Dakota State University

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| Criminology Club Faculty Advisor | 2023 – 2024 |
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Student Mentorship

Georgia Southern University

- Graduate:* Abisoye Adeniyi, Cheyenne Harvey, Joshua Robinson
- Undergraduate:* Jeremiah Davallou

South Dakota State University

- Ph.D. Committee, Sociology (Defended 2024):* Damilola Adereti
- Ph.D. Committee, Computational Science & Statistics (Current):* Dylan Borchert
- Karen McComish Fellowship Mentor:* Margaret Schliepsiek

Undergraduate Research: Chloe Beavers, Chloe Bender, Morgan Hunt

TRAINING, CERTIFICATIONS, & AWARDS

Certifications & Professional Training

Post-Baccalaureate Certificate in Crime Analysis, Radford University
Preparing Future Faculty, University of South Carolina
Teaching Toward Inclusive Excellence, University of South Carolina
Fostering Proactive Learning Environments, University of South Carolina

Awards & Honors

Competitive Travel Supplement, Georgia Southern University 2025
Discover USC Graduate Student Presenter Award, University of South Carolina 2021

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

Academy of Criminal Justice Sciences (ACJS)	2019 – Present
American Society of Criminology (ASC)	2019 – Present
Environmental Criminology and Crime Analysis (ECCA)	2023 – Present
European Society of Criminology (ESC)	2025 – Present
Southern Criminal Justice Association (SCJA)	2020 – 2022

TECHNICAL SKILLS

GIS (ArcGIS, QGIS) | L^AT_EX | R | Stata

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Forestry and GIS Technician , Eastern Forest Consultants	2015 – 2016
GIS Research Field Assistant , Virginia Tech	2015 – 2016
Conservation Land Monitor , Virginia Outdoors Foundation	2014 – 2015